official chairman was Isak Chishi Swu, a Sema Naga from Chishilimi village in Nagaland.

Its quaintly jumbled ‘Manifesto’, issued on 31 January 1980 and which was written by Muivah, quoted Mao emphasizing that a revolutionary organization must have ‘correct policies’, and went on to praise ‘the Christian God, the Eternal God of the Universe’. The manifesto stated that ‘to us the sovereign existence of our country, the salvation of our people is Socialism with their spiritual salvation in Christ are eternal and unquestionable’ and went on to reject the idea of a multiparty system, paraphrasing Maoist jargon, ‘To achieve socialism, the dictatorship of the people through a revolutionary organisation is absolutely indispensable.’ That organization was, of course, the NSCN which promised to liberate the Nagas from ‘the exploiting class…of reactionary traitors, the bureaucrats, a handful of rich men and the Indian vermin’.[80] Such mumbo-jumbo probably did not impress the Chinese, who had stopped providing the Naga rebels with military training in China after 1976. But links between them and the Chinese were never completely severed.

The only territory, and later state, in India’s northeastern region that has never had any armed insurrection is Arunachal Pradesh, the erstwhile NEFA. One reason could be the ethnic diversity of the rugged and extremely mountainous area, where dozens of different tribes have for centuries lived more or less isolated from each other. Another possible explanation is that Western missionaries never went there. The missionaries had not preached separatism, but the introduction of written languages, a literature, and a firm belief in something other than a host of spirits had created a sense of nationhood among, for instance, the Nagas and the Mizos. This in turn led to local nationalist movements, which eventually became armed, anti-government forces.

Two entirely different personalities are closely associated with the emergence of the NEFA, Verrier Elwin and Nari Rostomji. Elwin, a British missionary who had married a tribal woman from central India, converted to Hinduism in 1935 and became an Indian citizen after independence. Rustomji was an Indian Parsi and a product of the Indian Civil Service, a meticulous bureaucrat with strong feelings for India’s northern frontiers. Elwin was a close confidante of Nehru, who wrote the foreword to his book *A Philosophy for NEFA*, which was published in 1957.[81] The emphasis should be on education and economic development, Elwin stated, and not